REPORT 04 / UK SME AI ADOPTION INTELLIGENCE

How UK businesses use AI

Research is the highest listed use-case point estimate in every size group. Summarising or drafting is also prominent, especially for medium and large businesses.

Seven published use cases reveal where reported activity is concentrated.

EVIDENCE SCOPE

Table 42 describes all UK businesses. Businesses could select more than one use case, so categories overlap and must not be added together.

UKBDS Official source	95% Uncertainty	SMEs Primary scope
DSIT 2026	Intervals retained	Large shown separately

DAL Data & AI Lab | Benedek Moricz | 29 July 2026

Executive summary

#1 Research	#2 Summarise/draft	7 Published categories
Highest listed use case	Close second	Multiple response

The leading reported purposes are information-oriented: researching information and summarising or drafting. Specialised uses such as coding, cybersecurity and customer chatbots have lower point estimates, particularly among micro and small businesses.

Information work leads
Research is highest across all four size groups; summarising/drafting is also consistently prominent.

Technical use is narrower
Data analysis, coding and cybersecurity have lower point estimates than the two leading information tasks.

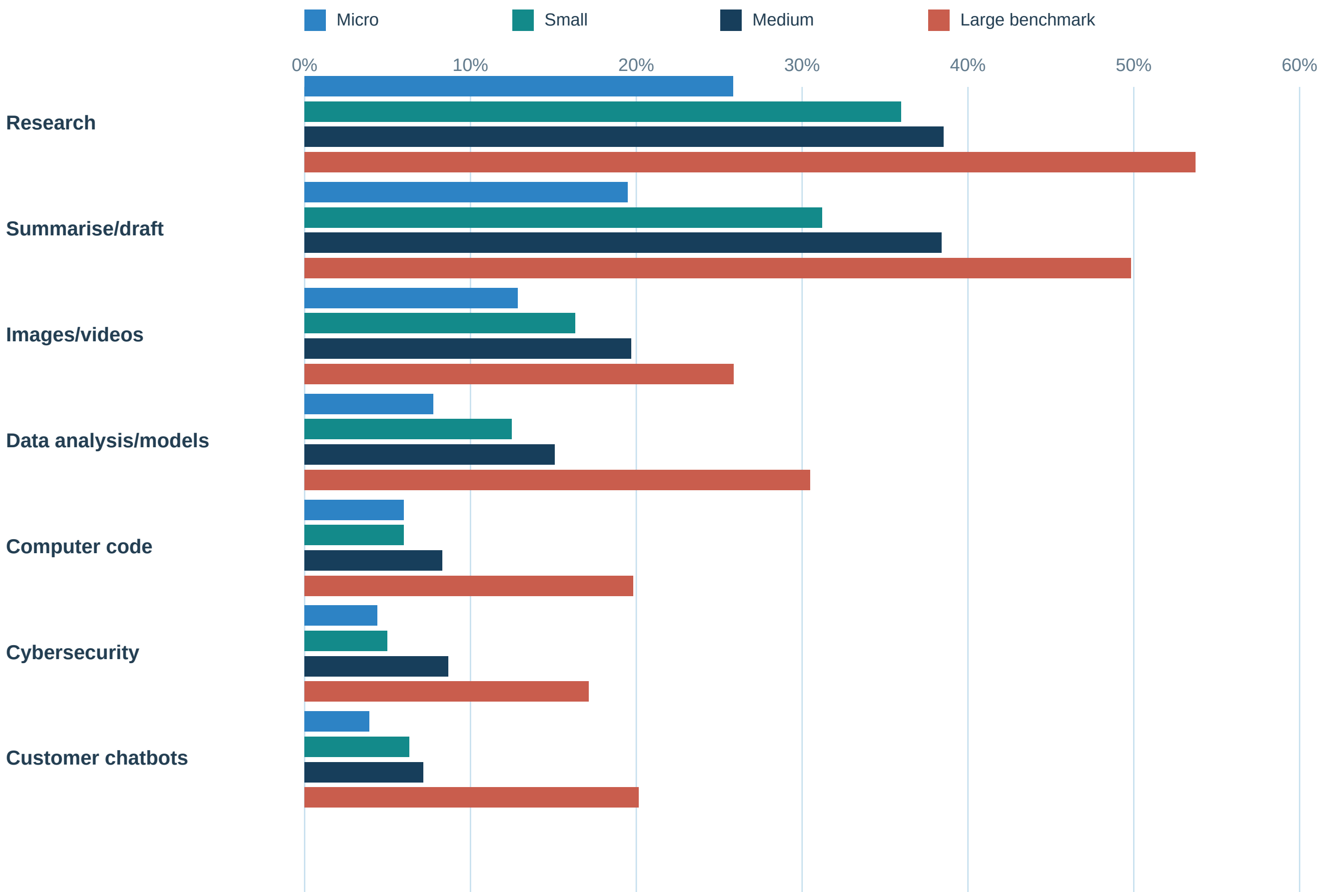
Size differences recur
The large-business benchmark is higher across all seven listed categories.

The categories overlap
A business may report several purposes, so the percentages describe incidence, not a portfolio that sums to 100%.

Useful insight: current reported use appears weighted toward information and content tasks rather than highly embedded technical applications.

Use-case profile by business size

Point estimates across seven multiple-response categories.



Blue bars show SME groups; teal marks the large-business benchmark. Confidence intervals are retained in the exact-value tables on the following pages.

Do not add the category percentages: businesses could report more than one purpose.

Exact SME estimates and confidence intervals

Use case	Micro	Small	Medium	Large*
Research	25.9% 24.0-27.7%	36.0% 32.0-39.9%	38.5% 31.5-45.5%	53.7% 44.7-62.8%
Summarise/draft	19.5% 17.8-21.2%	31.2% 27.4-35.0%	38.4% 31.4-45.4%	49.8% 40.8-58.9%
Images/videos	12.9% 11.4-14.3%	16.3% 13.3-19.4%	19.7% 14.0-25.4%	25.9% 17.9-33.8%
Data analysis/models	7.8% 6.6-8.9%	12.5% 9.8-15.2%	15.1% 9.9-20.2%	30.5% 22.1-38.8%
Computer code	6.0% 5.0-7.0%	6.0% 4.0-7.9%	8.3% 4.3-12.3%	19.8% 12.6-27.0%
Cybersecurity	4.4% 3.5-5.3%	5.0% 3.2-6.8%	8.7% 4.6-12.7%	17.1% 10.3-24.0%
Customer chatbots	3.9% 3.1-4.8%	6.3% 4.3-8.3%	7.2% 3.5-10.9%	20.1% 12.9-27.4%

Each cell shows the central estimate and, beneath it, the supplied 95% confidence interval.

Rounded respondent bases

2,500	680	220	130
Micro	**Small**	**Medium**	**Large***
Respondents	Respondents	Respondents	Respondents

Business interpretation: start with the task

The use-case profile supports a task-first conversation. It does not show whether the reported tools are effective, frequent or integrated.

Task value Which recurring information or content task consumes time and has a clearly defined quality standard?	**Risk and review** What data, legal, customer or reputational risk would require stronger human checking?
Workflow fit Is the tool used occasionally, or can it be connected safely to an existing process?	**Evidence of benefit** What before-and-after measure could test usefulness without assuming productivity gains?

Cross-use-case insight

- Research and summarising/drafting form a broad information-work cluster across sizes.
- Data analysis/models rises with size in the point estimates and is particularly higher for the large benchmark.
- Coding, cybersecurity and customer chatbots remain more specialised among SMEs in the published point estimates.
- Later sector analysis should test whether this pattern changes in technology, accounting and financial services.

> **The most useful next question is not simply 'Do you use AI?' but 'For which task, with what controls, and with what evidence of benefit?'**

Method, interpretation and source trail

These reports retain the survey definitions rather than treating every percentage as directly comparable.

Source and fieldwork

Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, UK Business Data Survey 2026. Fieldwork ran from 10 October 2025 to 28 January 2026. Source tables used: Table 42.

Denominator

All UK businesses within each published business-size category.

Uncertainty and bases

The official central estimates and supplied 95% confidence intervals are shown. Unweighted sample bases are rounded respondent counts, not counts of UK businesses. The medium and large groups generally have wider intervals because their bases are smaller.

Interpretation limits

- The findings are descriptive. They do not establish causation or business impact.
- The published package does not provide the covariance, replicate weights, raw microdata or official pairwise method needed for a fully defensible size-group significance test.
- Large businesses are a separate benchmark and are not part of the primary SME result.
- This is a multiple-response question. Categories overlap and must not be summed.
- The survey does not measure frequency, quality, productivity or return on investment for each use case.

Official material

UK Business Data Survey 2026 publication
UK Business Data Survey 2026 technical report

> **Use this evidence as a disciplined starting point for questions and prioritisation - not as a substitute for organisation-specific assessment.**